inscription ‘of the eleventh year of Mahapala I [c. 999 CE] refers to the destruction of Nalanda by fire and its subsequent restoration’.[34]

The second source is the account of Persian historian Minhaj al-Siraj, who was a child at the time of the alleged invasion and wrote from second-hand accounts he gathered forty years later. Al-Siraj, however, does not mention Nalanda at all; only that Khilji attacked and captured ‘the fortified city of Bihar’ and ‘acquired great booty’. Inside the city was a college ‘with a great number of books’ and an unspecified number of ‘Brahmans’ with ‘their heads shaven’, who ‘were all slain’ by Khilji’s army. Going by this clue, as some scholars have argued, it was the monastery of Uddandapura (aka Odantapuri), located on a hill within the fortified town of Bihar Sharif (Khilji and his men likely conflated that Buddhist monastery with a Brahminical ‘college’; Buddhism had nearly vanished by then in the north-western regions from where Khilji came).[35]

The town of Bihar Sharif was then a political and economic centre, presiding over a fertile hinterland fed by several rivers. When I visited Uddandapura during my stay in Bihar Sharif, I was struck by the lure of riches and power that its hill fort must have held to an expansionist army. Excavations show that its fort and monastery were remodelled and used by later Muslim rulers. Unlike Bihar Sharif, Nalanda had little political or economic allure, and it wasn’t a thriving centre of religion patronized by rival kings. On the contrary, it was struggling for survival under the hostile Sena Dynasty.[36] Nalanda was perhaps also lucky because, as a scholar claims, it ‘lay not on the main route from Delhi to Bengal, but required a special expedition’.[37] Though a direct distance of 12–15 km isn’t prohibitive, there may also have been a forest then—with snakes, tigers and black bears—between Nalanda and the army’s main route to Bengal via Bihar Sharif, implying a longer detour.

The third source is a biography of Dharmasvamin. After returning to Tibet, he described his two years of study at Nalanda, c. 1234–36, to his biographer, who wrote a third-person account of the journey, partly in his own words.[38] Though much diminished, Nalanda was still operating during Dharmasvamin’s visit. His account doesn’t mention Khilji, only that many monasteries at Nalanda had been ‘damaged by the Turks and there was